

100 Jeremiah

The weeping prophet who warned Jerusalem for forty years and promised a new covenant.

Jeremiah was a young man from a priestly family in Anathoth when God called him in King Josiah's thirteenth year. For about forty years, through Judah's last kings, he warned that Babylon would destroy Jerusalem unless the people turned back to God. Few listened. He was beaten, put in the stocks, thrown into a muddy cistern and accused of treason. He wept and argued honestly with God. Yet he bought a field during the siege as a sign of hope, and foretold a new covenant written on the heart. He saw Jerusalem fall and ended his days in Egypt.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yirmeyahu</i> , perhaps "the LORD lifts up"
Family	Son of Hilkiah, priest of Anathoth; unmarried (Jeremiah 1:1; 16:2)
When	c. 627 BC to after Jerusalem's fall in 586 BC
Key places	Anathoth, Jerusalem, the court of the prison, Egypt
Key people	Baruch, Jehoiakim, Zedekiah, Ebed-melech, Gedaliah
Main passages	Jeremiah 1–52; 2 Chronicles 35:25; 36:12, 21
New Testament	Matthew 2:17–18; 16:14; Hebrews 8:8–12

"Before I formed thee in the belly I knew thee; and before thou camest forth out of the womb I sanctified thee, and I ordained thee a prophet unto the nations."

Jeremiah 1:5, KJV

The life of Jeremiah

Dates are approximate (BC). The book is not in time order, so entries gather events from different chapters.

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| c. 627 BC
<i>13th year of Josiah</i> | ● Called as a youth
He says he is only a child. God touches his mouth and sets him over nations. <i>Jeremiah 1:1–10</i> |
| c. 609 BC
<i>Start of Jehoiakim's reign</i> | ● The temple sermon
He warns that the temple will not save lawbreakers. Priests demand his death, but Ahikam protects him. <i>Jeremiah 7:1–15; 26:1–24</i> |
| c. 605–604 BC
<i>Jehoiakim's 4th–5th years</i> | ● The scroll burned
Baruch reads Jeremiah's words in the temple. The king cuts up the scroll and burns it, and Jeremiah dictates it again. <i>Jeremiah 36:1–32</i> |
| c. 594 BC
<i>4th year of Zedekiah</i> | ● The yoke
Jeremiah wears a yoke and tells the nations to serve Babylon. Hananiah breaks it and dies that year. <i>Jeremiah 27:2–12; 28:1–17</i> |
| c. 588 BC
<i>During the siege</i> | ● Prison and the cistern
Arrested as a deserter, he is lowered into a muddy cistern, and Ebed-melech pulls him out. <i>Jeremiah 37:11–38:13</i> |
| c. 587 BC
<i>10th year of Zedekiah</i> | ● Buys a field
From prison he buys his cousin's field at Anathoth as a sign that fields will again be bought. <i>Jeremiah 32:1–15</i> |
| c. 586 BC
<i>Jerusalem falls</i> | ● Set free
The Babylonians release him, and he stays with Gedaliah at Mizpah. <i>Jeremiah 39:1–14; 40:1–6</i> |
| After c. 586 BC
<i>In Egypt</i> | ● Carried away
After Gedaliah is murdered, the survivors flee to Egypt and take Jeremiah and Baruch with them. <i>Jeremiah 41:1–43:7; 44:1</i> |

Key activities

Jeremiah is often called "the weeping prophet." Tradition names him as the author of Lamentations, though the book itself does not name its author.

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- I Accepted a hard call.** He felt too young, but God said, "Behold, I have put my words in thy mouth." *Jeremiah 1:6-9*

 - 2 Preached at the temple gate.** He told Judah to amend their ways, and warned that the temple had become "a den of robbers." *Jeremiah 7:1-11*

 - 3 Acted out God's message.** He used a linen girdle, a potter's clay, a broken bottle and a wooden yoke as signs. *Jeremiah 13:1-11; 18:1-6; 19:1-11; 27:2*

 - 4 Suffered for the truth.** Pashur the priest had him beaten and put in the stocks. *Jeremiah 20:1-2*

 - 5 Poured out his heart.** He complained bitterly to God, yet said the word was like "a burning fire shut up in my bones." *Jeremiah 20:7-18*

 - 6 Wrote to the exiles.** He told them to build houses, plant gardens and seek the peace of Babylon, for they would return after seventy years. *Jeremiah 29:4-14*

 - 7 Promised a new covenant.** God would write his law in their hearts and remember their sin no more. *Jeremiah 31:31-34*

 - 8 Bought a field in a war zone.** He paid for land the Babylonians were about to take, trusting that nothing was too hard for God. *Jeremiah 32:6-27*

 - 9 Spoke plainly to a weak king.** He told Zedekiah in secret that surrender to Babylon would save the city. *Jeremiah 38:14-23*

 - 10 Stayed with those left behind.** Offered a place in Babylon, he chose to stay with those left in the land. *Jeremiah 40:1-6*

 - II Warned against fleeing to Egypt.** He told the survivors to remain in Judah, but they would not listen. *Jeremiah 42:7-43:4*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Jeremiah.

Old Testament

Jeremiah 1–52	His book of prophecies, laments and history
2 Chronicles 35:25	He wrote a lament for Josiah
2 Chronicles 36:12, 21–22; Ezra 1:1	Zedekiah ignored him; the return fulfilled his word
Daniel 9:2	Daniel reads his prophecy of seventy years
Echo: Ezekiel 1:1–3	The same message to the exiles in Babylon

New Testament

Matthew 2:17–18	Rachel weeping (Jeremiah 31:15) and Bethlehem's children
Matthew 16:14	Some thought Jesus was "Jeremias"
Matthew 21:13	"A den of thieves," echoing Jeremiah 7:11
Luke 22:20; Hebrews 8:8–12	The new covenant; Hebrews quotes Jeremiah 31:31–34
Tradition	Later writers say he was stoned in Egypt; Scripture is silent

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What excuse did Jeremiah give, and how did God answer it (Jeremiah 1:6–9)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God had Jeremiah buy a field just before Jerusalem fell (Jeremiah 32:6–15)?
3. *Apply:* Jeremiah told God exactly how he felt. What would it look like for you to be that honest with God in prayer?
4. *Apply:* The exiles were told to seek the good of the city where they lived. What is one way you could do that where you live?